

Collection Plan Analysis: Library of Congress

Overview

The Library of Congress (LOC) *Collections Policy Statements Supplementary Guidelines* on web archiving represents a cohesion between the libraries traditional mission – acquiring, cataloging, preserving, and providing access to historical materials (the intellectual, commercial, and creative underpinnings of life under the United States Government) – and the nature of web content; that is, the rapidly changing landscape of digital technologies associated with the acquisition and use of data objects found on webpages: jpeg images, html scripts, or anything that can be secured through archival-quality harvesting software, or web crawlers. There is an emphasis on the intellectual entity (such as text) that frames the user experience and the analog-ness of the content. If possible, these collections or materials can be retrieved in much the same way as a book or painting can be stored or located. There is an emphasis on replicating the appearance and functionality of the website when it was first captured, and interactive or dynamic components (like java applets or other executables) are usually sacrificed due to technical limitations of crawlers or because preservation based on artifactual or intrinsic value is costly at scale – tracking physical custody and intellectual control (through the necessary documentation) requires space and time, both of which are shortages in our profession, apparently even at the Library of Congress. Their web archive selection process lines up with other policy initiatives supporting subject-area – including policy statements on diversity and inclusion (LGBTQIA+ Studies or Women's and Gender Studies, for example) – and a more general library-wide collection policy statement guides the selection of websites. The

predominant focus, the planning, and the execution of record management and archival programs for the web at the LOC belongs first and foremost to government recordkeeping, a national recordkeeping regime recounting the tantalizing possibilities in the sites of federal agencies, house and senate committees, legislative websites, and more broadly the branches of government. High-priority acquisitions respond to the categorical imperatives and ontological makeup of the LOC's classificatory system.

While selection and admission are inevitable, in what follows I would like to advance the following problematics: Although the LOC emphasizes strong centralized control, the structural coupling of policy and planning with values and ethics, and the practices of reliability, collaboration, and shared purpose, common to the best types of institutions, the library is still designed to explain after the fact, and what it chooses to explain is the operative chain of statecraft—the prejudices and antipathies of infrastructures that enable violence and narrative control.

Terry Cook, in a 2013 article, disambiguates between the four shifting archival paradigms of evidence, memory, identity, and community. In this constellation, The LOC, and archives in general, no longer claim institutional objectivity, their innards exposed as constructed cultural memory. On the slaughterbench of history, archivists reinvent and shapeshift, take control of their infrastructural power and drive epistemological recalibration through community initiative. Taking the baton from Cook, I would like to propose a new paradigm for collection and appraisal analysis, where archiving, and web archiving in particular, come to champion an investigative aesthetic, a counter-forensic: what matters now is not what happened after the fact, but the conditions under which what happened can become intelligible. Librarians and archivists have a role to play in the collective process of truthmaking, in staging truth as transparent through

material witness. Collection plans and guidelines should center around the activation of the archive, redistributing evidentiary power to design publics around truth.

Strengths, Assumptions and Limitations.

Murray & Hsieh's (2006) identified seven critical factors (consortial approach, user evaluation, copyright, policies, organizational support, resources, and technology) for web archiving found the preconditions for collection policy and guidelines at the LOC: vernaculars of cooperation and partnerships, envisioned through consortial models, help to supplement the Libraries capacities; subject experts and researchers collaboratively develop and promote selectivities in accordance with the libraries annual collection priorities, infusing a sense of user evaluation into collections; copyright concerns tag along behind the libraries permission processes and notice procedures for site owners; high-level collection policies set the stakes for recommending and acquiring divisions who face the organizational support (or the the thunderous clamp) of library management or the Web Archive Collection Development Group (WACDG) – an interdepartmental group who reviews new collection proposals or collection update requests quarterly; resource allocation and technological requirements further constrain the preservation of web materials. It is under these assumptions that the LOC performs domain capture—archiving web-based materials for our national governing body and according to broader acquisitional policies dealing with the usefulness of serving the resources that already stand in the libraries collection. Such usefulness is sociotechnical: appraisal values document the social, cultural, and temporal architecture of existing hierarchies and streams of influence built into already-existing institutional governance and classification systems. The institutionalization of these frameworks into formal collecting policies necessitates the contact and collapse of both strength and weakness. On the one hand, scope and selection priorities highlight institutional

readiness and organizational cooperation, enacted through Murray & Hsieh's (2006) seven factors. On the other hand, legislation, policies, and standards can obstruct effective digital record capture, management, and preservation, especially as new vehicles and structures for the exchange of information become more prevalent online. Active participation in the digital age demands agility, focus, intimacy, and speed. Of course, web archives still require funding and staff time—certainly the value of the collection means nothing if it cannot be built and sustained—and thus the snake begins to eat its own tail: Strengths become weaknesses, weaknesses strengths, and vice versa.

Conclusion

Completeness requires the activation of the archive and the abandonment of the status quo. Under its current collection policies, the LOC is complicit in rendering important aspects of life on the web invisible, falling short of its mission to document and preserve the intellectual, commercial and creative life of the United States. The LOC maintains the technical infrastructure and expertise in storage media risk management, and yet its collections capitulate to congress. It is through the archive that we catch a faint glance of ourselves in the tides—always ever an old situationship of longing and nostalgia instead of an epistemological posture, a conceptual spine to hold ourselves up to the real. Polycrisis events threaten the very existence of digital archives and our user communities of the future. Yet, we posture in the ethics and the institutional awe of our profession. It is time for our practices to salvage the fragmentary sequences of materialization and mediatization into a narrative that offers an architectonics of memory. Only then will the LOC begin to document the bewildering richness of American life online. The archives are an occluded reality, and the LOC is a wonderful example of how bureaucratic control and institutional oversight actually delimit the heterogeneity of what could be acquired,

ingested, and preserved. Turning towards a recalibration of the archives and the work that we do allows our profession to shape democratic public ownership in the 21st century. Of course, we continue to follow in Cook's (2013) and the broader archival communities footsteps, linking the social, political, and cultural factors that shape collection policies and appraisal, the psycho-philosophical and mythical concepts related to forgetting and remembering, and the present day concerns around technological determinism and digital infrastructure to the overall telos of meaning-making and truth-seeking. Although the LOC's collection plan may be successfully implemented in its strategic outline and institutional buffering, it remains insufficient for our current conjuncture and the undertaking that is necessary to secure our future in the now.

References

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